

Background Guide UNHRC - CSMUN 4.0

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Letter from the Executive Board

Distinguished delegates,

We extend our warmest welcome to all of you as the executive board members of the United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) committee for CSMUN 2026! We are excited to embark on this incredible conference with you and anticipate that it will be filled with meaningful debates, research, and diplomacy.

The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) is an intergovernmental body within the United Nations system, headquartered in Geneva, Switzerland. Established in 2006, its core mandate is to promote and protect human rights globally, address severe rights violations, and provide recommendations on how to enforce them. As chairs, we are eager to see how each of you will contribute to this committee and find solutions that could make a significant impact.

We encourage you to immerse yourself in the topic at hand, research thoroughly, and be well-prepared for the conference, as your dedication and hard work will not only benefit your own experience but also contribute to the overall success of the committee. Engaging in a successful committee will allow you and your respective delegates to all put yourself out there without holding back.

This conference is not about winning an award but it is a learning experience, one that helps you enhance in so many skills, from public speaking, to current affairs, to literary expertise. It will certainly be a unique opportunity for you to develop your diplomatic skills, negotiation skills, and confidence.

This Background Guide is intended to provide context for the agenda, but not the sole research tool. Delegates are encouraged to conduct independent research and represent the official positions and stance of their countries throughout the committee.

If you have any questions or need assistance at any point during your research or during the conference, please do not hesitate to reach out to us and we will assist you in any way possible.

Goodluck,
Executive Board of CSMUN 4.0
Shreyal Kothapalli, Michelle Maria Samuel

1) Introduction to the Committee

A- History and Purpose of UNHRC

- Established in 2006 by UN General Assembly Resolution 60/251, replacing the UN Commission on Human Rights
- Subsidiary body of the UNGA, composed of 47 member states elected on a regional grouping basis for staggered three-year terms.
- Mandate: Promote universal respect for human rights, address violations and respond to human rights emergencies.
- Important : Universal Periodic Review (UPR), Special Procedures (rapporteurs), Complaint procedure and special sessions.
- Resolutions are not legally binding but carry significant political and normative weight and can mandate fact-finding missions of inquiry.
- Delegates should research-composition of the current council, voting blocs(OIC,NAAM etc.) and how prior special sessions have shaped state behavior.

Sources: [ohchr.org/en/ohchr_homepage](https://www.ohchr.org/en/ohchr_homepage), docs.un.org/en/A/RES/60/251

2) Basic Overview of the Agenda

A- What is a Special Session?

- A Special Session is an extraordinary meeting of the UNHRC convened outside its regular calendar to address urgent human rights situations.
- Can be requested by one member state with support of at least one-third of the Council's membership (16 states).
- Typically results in a focused resolution, a fact-finding mission, or appointment of a Special Rapporteur.

B- Demand of the Agenda

- Council is called upon to address the compounding humanitarian crisis in the Middle East as it intersects with maritime security and freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz.
- Core points-framework reconciling security concerns with human rights and maritime law obligations, protection of seafarers and civilian shipping, accountability for attacks on civilian ships, economic dimension with respect to livelihood, food etc.
- Delegates should research their state's stake (energy dependence, seafarer nationals employed on commercial fleets, trade exposure) to frame national positions.

Sources: www.unocha.org, main.un.org/securitycouncil/en

C- Significance of the Strait of Hormuz, map of the strait

- Narrow chokepoint (as little as 33 km wide) connecting the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and Arabian Sea; bordered by Iran (north) and Oman/UAE (south).

- Historically carries roughly a fifth of global oil trade and a similar share of LNG trade - among the world's most strategically vital waterways
- Only viable maritime export route for most Gulf oil producers (Saudi Arabia and UAE have limited pipeline alternatives; Qatar's LNG exports depend almost entirely on it)
- Used as leverage by Iran in past and present confrontations; closure or disruption immediately affects global energy prices, food/fertiliser shipments and humanitarian logistics.
- Map of the strait- UN Digital Library "Strait of Hormuz" [cartographic material]
digitallibrary.un.org/record/121834?v=pdf

Sources : iea.org/about/oil-security-and-emergency-response/strait-of-hormuz,

3) Historical Background

A- Tanker War (1940s)

- Maritime phase of the Iran-Iraq War (1980-1988) in which both belligerents attacked neutral oil tankers in the Gulf to damage each other's oil exports.
- Led to internationalisation of the conflict: US, UK, France and others escorted/reflagged tankers (e.g. US "Operation Earnest Will") and deployed naval forces to the Gulf.
- The US Navy clashed directly with Iranian forces, including "Operation Praying Mantis" (1988), one of the largest US surface naval engagements since WWII.
- Set the precedent for great-power naval presence in the Strait and for treating freedom of navigation there as an international, not merely regional, concern.

Sources: CBP-10636: commonslibrary.parliament.uk/research-briefings/cbp-10636,

B- USS Vincennes Incident

- On 3 July 1988, the USS Vincennes shot down Iran Air Flight 655 over the Strait of Hormuz, killing all 290 people on board, after misidentifying the civilian airliner as an attacking aircraft.
- US later paid compensation (without admitting legal liability) following proceedings before the International Court of Justice
- Frequently cited by Iran as evidence of Western military recklessness in the Strait and remains a reference point in current Iran-US distrust narratives.

Sources: ICJ -N Aerial Incident of 3 July 1988 (Iran v. United States) - icj-cij.org/case/79

C- Iran- Hamas Conflict

- Conflict reignited after the 7 October 2023 Hamas led attack on Israel and the subsequent Israeli military campaign in Gaza, producing a large-scale humanitarian crisis.
- Regional spillover: Iran-aligned actors (notably the Houthis in Yemen and Hezbollah in Lebanon) framed attacks on shipping and Israel as solidarity action, widening instability across the Red Sea and Eastern Mediterranean.
- Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping caused major rerouting of global trade and are an important comparative case for maritime human rights/security debates relevant to Hormuz.

- Should research on the current status of the Gaza ceasefire talks and how the conflict has shaped Iran's regional posture heading into the Hormuz crisis.

Sources: UN OCHA - occupied Palestinian territory: unocha.org/middle-east-and-north-africa, un.org/securitycouncil/en

D- Escalation of War between USA, Iran

- Failed nuclear negotiations and a prior short conflict in 2025 set the stage for renewed escalation.
- 28 February 2026: US and Israel launched coordinated strikes on Iran ("Operation Epic Fury"), killing Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and triggering large-scale Iranian retaliation against Israel and US bases/allies in the Gulf.
- 4 March 2026: Iran declared the Strait of Hormuz "closed," laid mines, and attacked transiting vessels, collapsing shipping traffic by over 90%.
- A ceasefire was reached (7-8 April 2026) and extended through subsequent negotiations (Pakistani mediation); a memorandum of understanding was signed by the US and Iranian presidents in June 2026, though sporadic attacks on shipping and skirmishes have continued even after the ceasefire.
- Iran has continued to assert practical control over passage, and the US has maintained a counter-blockade on Iranian ports, making the Strait's status central to ongoing diplomacy

Sources: UN Secretary General Statements- press.un.org/en/statements-and-messages

4) Humanitarian crises

A - General crises

- Escalating attacks in Iran and Lebanon and the spread of conflict across the Middle East has been devastating
- Even before the recent escalations, more than 24 million people across the affected countries were already forcibly displaced and returnees facing significant protection risks and humanitarian needs, alongside host communities.
- **Refugee crisis:**
 - The affected areas already host 24.3 million forcibly displaced people, many of whom, alongside host communities, face significant protection risks and humanitarian needs.
 - With limited funding, many countries are struggling to meet existing needs, making it increasingly difficult to absorb additional pressures and support newly displaced populations.
 - An inter-agency emergency response has been launched to address urgent needs across the region
- **Health care crises**
 - National health authorities in Iran report more than 1300 deaths and 9000 injuries, and in Lebanon report at least 570 deaths and more than 1400 injuries. In Israel, authorities report 15 deaths and 2142 injuries.

- The conflict is affecting the very services meant to save lives.
- In Iran, WHO has verified 18 attacks on health care since 28 February, resulting in 8 deaths among health workers. Over the same period in Lebanon, 25 attacks on health care have resulted in 16 deaths and 29 injuries. These attacks not only cost lives but deprive communities of care when they need it most.

Sources -

Middle East emergencies - <https://www.unhcr.org/emergencies/middle-east-emergency>

Health crises -

<https://www.who.int/news/item/11-03-2026-conflict-deepens-health-crisis-across-middle-east--who-says>
[Chokepoints and conflict: How the Hormuz crisis is exposing global shipping vulnerabilities | UN News](#)

B - Maritime Humanitarian Crises

● **Economic crises**

- The conflict threatens record levels of hunger, further complicated by the threat of global food inflation caused by blockages in key maritime shipping routes.
- The ripple effects of the Middle East escalation are also affecting parts of Asia, where many economies depend on imports and households already face tight purchasing power.
- In Afghanistan, the emergency adds to multiple crises affecting vulnerable families, including conflict with Pakistan and two major earthquakes in 2025.
- The Strait of Hormouz is a vital trade artery. By effectively restricting the passage of commercial cargo and energy supplies, the crisis has throttled the delivery of crucial regional aid and fertilizer raw materials.
- Across Asia, an estimated 45.5 million people are already in need of humanitarian assistance, with response plans targeting 27.2 million people and requiring \$3.6 billion in funding.
- Rising oil prices and reduced maritime traffic are driving up inflation in the form of transport, electricity and agricultural input costs across import-dependent economies in Asia – including Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal and the Philippines
- These pressures are layering onto pre-existing vulnerabilities – from high food insecurity to economic fragility
- The blockage and severe curtailment of tanker traffic have caused natural gas prices to surge, which is the foundational feedstock for nitrogen-based fertilizers
- Because fertilizers cannot be easily stockpiled, these soaring costs are crippling farmers globally—especially in developing nations and regions heavily dependent on Middle Eastern imports, such as Asia, Africa, and Australia.
- The Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) warns that this shock to fertilizer availability and agricultural productivity compromises both the volume and nutritional density of staple foods.
- The United Nations has cautioned that prolonged disruption in the Strait of Hormuz could push up to 45 million more people into hunger and starvation.

● **Maritime threats due to Strait of Hormouz blockade**

- The blockading of ships in the Strait of Hormuz as a result of the conflict between the United States and Iran has demonstrated how ships and seafarers have become “leverage in geopolitical disputes,” according to the head of the UN’s International Maritime Organization
- Arsenio Dominguez, Secretary General, IMO stated that “More recently, international shipping and seafarers have become caught up in geopolitical conflicts which are not their responsibility.” He stressed that seafarers must never become targets in geopolitical conflict.
- **Causalities :** Ships have been subject to uncrewed aerial and surface projectiles. These are civilian merchant vessels without the capabilities to defend themselves from these attacks.
 - Civilian seafarers are not combatants and should never be a targets
 - Since conflict began with the US-Israeli bombing of Iran in late February, up to 20,000 seafarers have been stranded on some 2,000 vessels in the Persian Gulf, which is bordered by Iran to the north, unable to pass safely through the narrow waterway.
- **Trapped crews:** Approximately 11,000 seafarers are stranded on roughly 600 ships unable to safely exit the region. Crews face prolonged exposure to war conditions, severe isolation, and disrupted crew changes.

Sources:

Food crises <https://www.wfp.org/stories/why-middle-east-conflict-threatens-record-levels-hunger>
[Strait of Hormuz Crisis Puts Seafarers on the Front Line of Escalating Gulf Conflict](#)
[Despite ceasefire, Hormuz tensions continue to throttle supply chains worldwide | UN News](#)
[Strait of Hormuz: Time running out to avert global food security crisis, FAO warns](#)

5) Legalities and Conventions in Question

A - Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948)

- **Article 3** Right to life and security.
- **Article 5** Freedom from torture.
- **Article 13** Freedom of movement.
- **Article 25** Right to adequate living conditions.

B - International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR)

- **Article 6** Right to life, livelihood, food
- **Article 7** Freedom from torture.
- **Article 9** Freedom from arbitrary detention.

C - United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS, 1982)

Part II – Territorial Sea

- **Article 17** Right of innocent passage.
- **Article 19** Defines innocent passage.

Relevance: [Immediately Restore Freedom of Navigation through Strait of Hormuz. Speakers Urge in Security Council Condemning Critical Waterway's Use as 'Bargaining Chip' | UN Meetings Coverage and Press Releases](#) -

The U.S. actions ignited a fundamental clash of legal architectures. The U.S. attempted to enforce the UNCLOS transit passage regime to keep the strait open for its warships. However, Iran—invoking the 1958 Geneva Convention's doctrine of "innocent passage"—argued that the U.S. violated its territorial sovereignty by launching an unprovoked war of aggression and navigating warships through its waters during active hostilities

- **Article 24** Coastal states shall not hamper innocent passage.

Part III – International Straits

The Strait of Hormuz is legally classified as an international strait.

D - Second Geneva Convention

Article 12 – Wounded, sick, and shipwrecked persons must be respected and protected.

Article 18 – Parties must search for and collect the shipwrecked, wounded, and sick after engagements.

Articles 22–35 – Protection of hospital ships.

6) Potential solutions

- Strengthen monitoring and reporting of human rights violations at sea.
- Protect civilian vessels, seafarers, and humanitarian aid under international law.
- Ensure safe and unhindered delivery of humanitarian assistance.
- Support independent investigations and accountability for violations.
- Promote dialogue and peaceful conflict resolution.
- Strengthen international cooperation on search and rescue and humanitarian response.

Questions for Delegates

How can civilians and seafarers be better protected in the Strait of Hormuz?

How can humanitarian aid be delivered safely during periods of conflict?

What measures can improve accountability for human rights violations at sea?

What role should the UNHRC play in monitoring and responding to the humanitarian crisis?

How can international cooperation help reduce tensions while protecting human rights?

Recent Developments

Source: [A bad peace: the Arab Gulf states and the US–Iran memorandum of understanding](#)

On 17 June 2026, United States President Donald Trump and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian remotely signed the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding Between the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran, or US–Iran MoU for short. The interim agreement is intended to formalise the ceasefire between Iran and the US and restore shipping through the Strait of Hormuz. It also sets out an extendable 60-day negotiating period for a final deal on the future of Iran’s nuclear programme. To incentivise Iran to comply, the US has committed to a range of economic and security concessions that, if a final deal is reached, would put an end to the American decades-long containment policy toward Iran.

June 25th IMO Statement: Following an attack on a vessel in the Gulf of Oman, IMO has decided to temporarily pause its evacuation operation for 11000 seafarers stranded in the Persian Gulf, amid ongoing regional conflict pending further clarity.

June 26 (Reuters) - The U.S. military attacked Iran on Friday in response to an Iranian drone strike on a cargo ship in the Strait of Hormuz, with each country accusing the other of violating terms of a ceasefire agreed on last week.